

Workshopping Creative Interactive Experiences

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Abstract

Bringing people together with the goal of creating an interactive performance concept can be a daunting task. Even if everyone shows up with a collaborative spirit, differences in disciplines and openness to outside-the-box flow can stall the creative process. Finding inspiration from technical elements rather than limitations is key. We highlight a case study here in which we used an abstract art exercise to open up creative flow and level the field of discussion. We then give a brief description of the concept arising from the exercise currently in development.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → *Human computer interaction (HCI)*.

Keywords

Workshop, Process, Art, Performance Art, Dance, Choreography, Design, Wearable Artistic Interactions

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1 Motivation

Create an interactive performance piece that is both technically innovative and artistically expressive while working with and educating students on process and movement. That is the goal and charge for an Artist-in-Residence at the Institute for People and Technology at the Georgia Institute of Technology. The Artist-in-Residence Corian Ellisor is a performance artist and choreographer working with accepted and classical performance creation methods, now excited to include interactive and technological advancements.

Through the Artist-in-Residence we hope to engage engineering and science students in new methods, processes, and potential

avenues for their expertise. The Artist in Residence interacts directly with students but also collaborates with faculty across the institute to lend artistic knowledge and support on projects while also utilizing technical advice and construction on their work.



Figure 1: Discussing ideas while working on abstract art. Photo by Royce Soble

2 Ideation Workshop

To kick start the Artist in Residence program, we set up a workshop that included engineers, scientists, visual artists, other choreographers, performance artists, students, staging experts, visual effects experts, and videographers. In total, there were 17 people in the workshop.

Ellisor prompted the workshop with the theme of world building. 'If you could build a world, what would that entail and using the five senses, how would we experience it?'

2.1 Workshop Format

The workshop was a 4 hour event that took place in a bright meeting / collaboration room. It began with an abstract art exercise led by a visual mixed-media artist / photographer. The purpose of all creating art together and drawing / mixed media in particular was to build shared meaning and also open our minds to creative thought. We have found this helpful in a number of previous workshops.



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[1–3] This however, is the first time we worked with a visual artist with the intention of non-direct ideation.

Discussion over drawing lead to robust conversations about possible outcomes for the performance.

2.2 Description of Intention from Abstract Artist Royce Soble

Abstract art making is open to interpretation by both the creator and the viewer. For me, this form of mark making is not only a method of producing artwork but a practice that helps me trust my feelings and energy. It pushes me to take risks, gives me permission to play, and allows me to release rigid ways of thinking.

When teaching, I intentionally use materials that offer endless possibilities and outcomes unique to each individual. A mixed media quality paper supports both wet and dry media, making it highly versatile. I provide watercolor pencils, high-flow acrylic paints, archival gel pens, and graphite pencils. Each participant receives a mini spray bottle to activate the paint, allowing them to control how the medium moves on the page. I also bring various tools for dragging and blending paint to build texture and create layered effects.

At the beginning of each session, I give a brief tutorial to demonstrate how the materials behave. Then I invite the group to adopt a mindset of “letting go of the rules.” Many of the people I work with—often engineers or scientists—tend to approach tasks analytically, leaning into left-brain thinking: logical, linear, structured. But abstract art making calls for a shift. It asks us to access the right brain—our emotion, intuition, and imagination—and to allow those qualities to lead the creative process.

For me personally, abstract work is deeply therapeutic. It offers a space to channel emotion through intention. I choose colors based on how I feel in the moment, and the marks I make often reflect the energy I’m holding and wish to express. It becomes an exercise in both creation and concentration. I can tune out the noise around me and be fully present with the art.

This isn’t always an easy or natural process. Giving yourself permission to “paint outside the lines” and move beyond your comfort zone can be challenging. But this way of art making opens the door to greater creative thinking. It expands our capacity to see not only art—but the world—in a more fluid, abstract, and open-ended way.

The performance artist’s response to the use of abstract art in the workshop was parallel to the intention and validating. “As a performance artist, I found the initial use of tactile fine art helped give a start and intention to the narrative of the project. We were able to create in real time and with our fine motor skills, works of art that helped the participants in the workshop to relax and share ideas.”

3 Concept

The performance concept that emerged from the workshop was a multi-phase interactive engagement. Working with students in an ubiquitous computing course. We are building what we are currently calling a “Story Booth”. This mobile booth will contain an AI agent with the voice and visage of our Artist in Residence. Participants will be invited to enter the booth and interact with

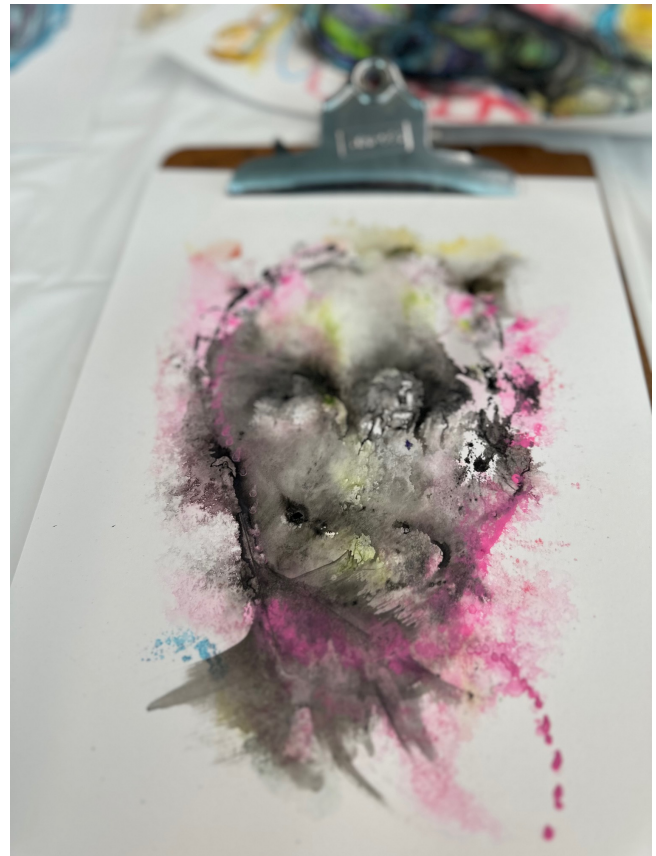


Figure 2: Artwork produced during the workshop, while ideating and discussing. Photo by Royce Soble

the agent, who will illicit stories containing visual world-building elements.

As the participant tells their story, the audio and video are recorded for future choreographed performances.

Ellis describes: “I will use each story as an outline for improvisational dance investigations. I will employ the use of the interviewer tone, inflection, and embellishments as guides for my movement exploration. I will be recording all of my investigations and extracting the movements that I find interesting / compelling. This will be the catalyst for generating material to create dance choreography.”

During the interaction in the booth, sentiment analysis will be used on the participants’ story. The outcome of this real-time analysis will change the lighting patterns and colors both inside and outside the box.

Eventually, the stories collected by the booth will be placed through a generative AI image application to create backdrops for Ellis’s performances. The goal would be that all this could happen in real time. A person could enter the booth, you would see their face on a screen, and the booth would light up as they begin to tell their world building story. As they continue, an image would begin to build within the dance space that becomes the stage for Ellis’s improvisational performance.

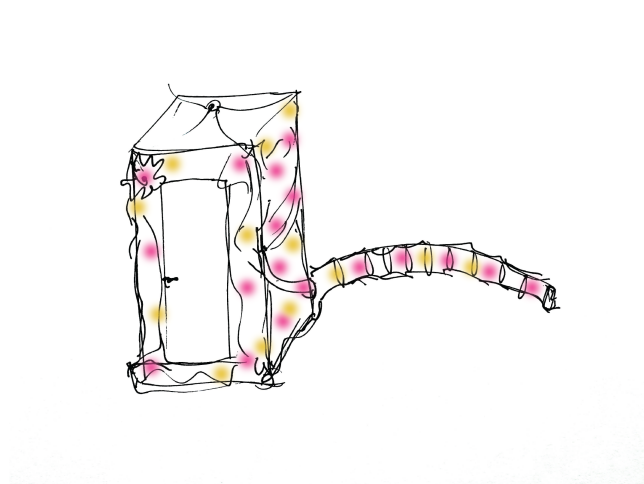


Figure 3: Sketch of Story Booth Concept.

4 Next Steps

We have been engaging with student teams and research faculty to start executing parts of the booth. We intend to install the booth in the university library to begin collecting stories from faculty and students. We also intend to install the booth at festivals and

pop-ups throughout September 2025. culminating performance will happen in November 2025.

When asked what drew Ellisor to the project he stated: "I am interested in the experience of actively incorporating live performance and digital content. There is a way to connect several experiences like the 5 senses at multiple times. I want to figure out how to make that happen in a compelling way. The digital space is ever growing and changing every second, so it is my job as an artist to adapt. One way to do this is to find something that is used for a specific thing and you use it for something else. I am thinking of a musical instrument that you wear and produces sound. Or, the use of someone telling their story could control the lighting of a performance. So far, this process has made me expand my perceived limitations. I have found confidence in simply asking for something and it may happen. This process is teaching me to think bigger and on a more grand scale."

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